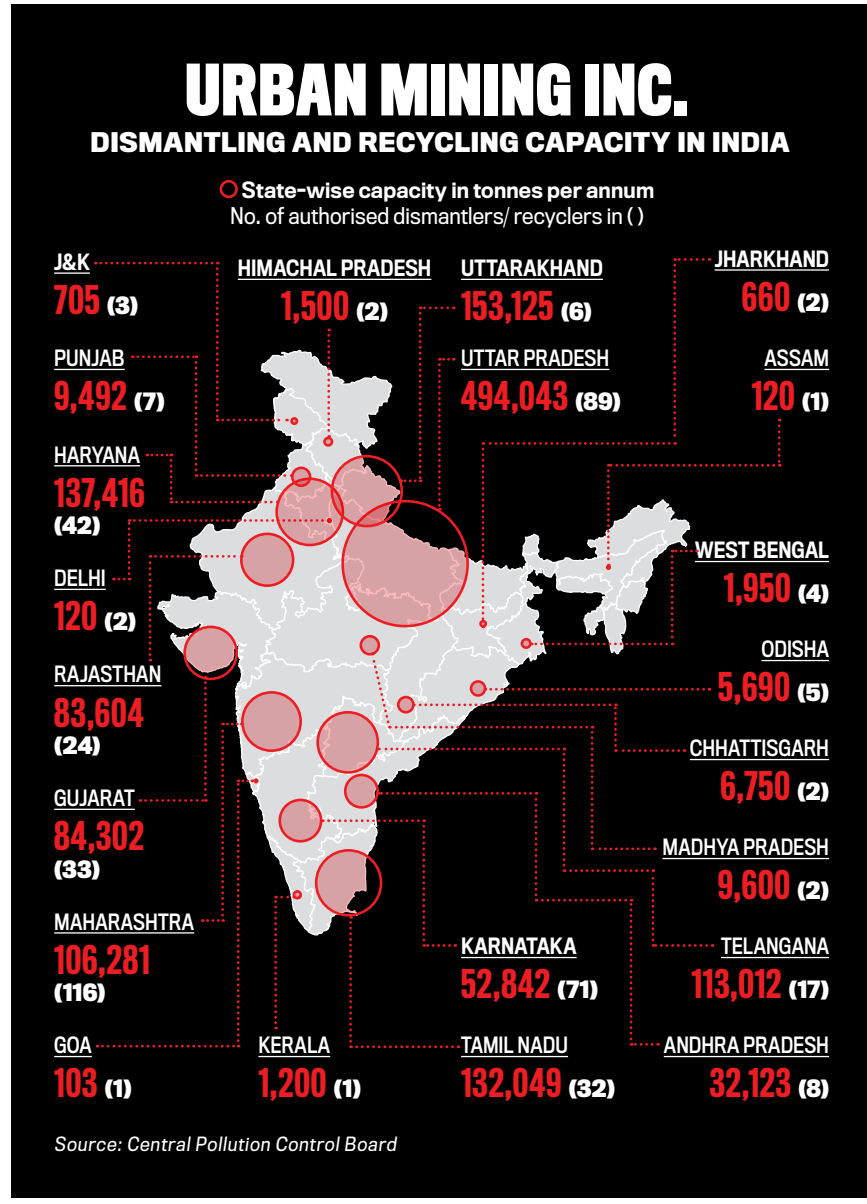




Ironically enough, in a country where rising junk levels are a problem, **formal recyclers complain** they don't get enough e-waste

calls, people would give their e-waste away for free. Now, he barely gets enough material to run his small unit for three months a year. There are more e-waste traders than recyclers and people like him can't outbid them. "This is not my problem, it's an industry-wide issue," he says.

Unlike European countries, who have had EPR since the early 1990s, in India, it is at a nascent stage, says Singh of CSE. "The informal sector has its set of strengths and weaknesses. The strength is collection," he says. It's the leakages into hazardous recycling that need to be plugged. But the way to formalise this supply chain is riddled with complexity because it's also a source of livelihood for thousands. "It will happen. But growth is going to be slow," says Parthasarathy of E-Parisaraa. "That is what happened in Germany, and in Switzerland too. Their collection rate was hardly 20 per cent when we (E-Parisaraa) started out. Now it has gone up." Collection rates of electrical and electronic equipment placed on the market in Germany and Switzerland, respectively, were 44.3 per cent (2019) and 68 per cent (2018).

In May, a draft set of new e-waste rules was circulated, proposing a revamp e-waste management in India. Exigo's Rao considers them a game-changer. Among other things, a much wider range of products will now come under the